

IN THE FOOTSTEPS OF
Bryan Blundell
1674 – 1756

Cabin Boy · Master Mariner · Merchant · Twice Mayor of Liverpool · School Founder ·

Slave Trader

A Self-Guided Walking Tour · Liverpool City Centre

About This Walk

Bryan Blundell was born in Liverpool on 30 December 1674 and baptised at St Nicholas Church a week later.

He rose from cabin boy to master mariner, from merchant to slave trader, and served twice as Mayor of his town. He co-founded what is now the Blue Coat School in 1708; one of Liverpool's most celebrated institutions, still thriving today.

This walk traces the Liverpool he knew, shaped, governed, and left behind. It takes approximately one and a half hours at a leisurely pace and covers roughly 2 miles. All venues are free to enter, with the exceptions of the Old Dock Tour and visiting inside the Town Hall (pre-booking essential for both).

The walk begins and ends at the waterfront where Blundell was baptised, married and buried.

Practical Information

Duration: Approximately one and a half hours walking (2.3 miles), but a full day (or longer) if you visit all the museums and galleries

Start and End point: St Nicholas Church (Our Lady and Saint Nicholas), Old Churchyard, Liverpool L2 8TZ

Old Dock Tour: Book in advance at liverpoolmuseums.org.uk — highly recommended

Town Hall Guided Tour: Book in advance at [Liverpool Town Hall](http://liverpooltownhall.org.uk)

Refreshments: Coffee and lunch available at The Bluecoat Arts Centre (Stop 5)

Shopping: Aldous Books, The Bluecoat, Liverpool, L1 3BX (Stop 5)

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Stop 1 St Nicholas Church (Our Lady and Saint Nicholas) — Where It All Began

Address: Old Churchyard, Liverpool L2 8TZ

Open: Monday–Sunday, 9:00am–5:00pm

Begin here, at the church where Bryan Blundell's story started. He was born on Sunday 30 December 1674 and baptised in this very church nine days later, on 9 January 1675. Known as the sailors' church, it has served Liverpool since at least the fourteenth century. Be sure to look for the ship weathervane on its spire which was erected in 1747 and matched the one installed on the top of Blue Coat School in 1717.

His father William funded the construction of a family gallery inside the church in 1687 and the family held a pew there for centuries. Young Bryan would have almost certainly sat in its pews every Sunday he was not at sea.

"Its bells tolled the rhythms of the waterfront, marking time, warning of storm, and calling the town to prayer."

— *The Story of Bryan Blundell*

Stand by the Mersey and look out across the water. Imagine leaving Liverpool for the first time as a 12-year-old boy on the *Reserve* for Barbados.



Stop 2 Museum of Liverpool

Walking time 8 minutes

Address: Pier Head, Mann Island, Liverpool L3 1DG

Open: Tuesday–Sunday, 10:00am–5:00pm • Free entry

Old Dock Tour: Book in advance — tours run throughout the day

Walk south along the waterfront from St Nicholas Church, past the Pier Head and the Three Graces: the Royal Liver Building, the Cunard Building, and the Port of Liverpool Building. These are the three monuments to the maritime ambition that Blundell helped set in motion. The Museum of Liverpool is the modern building on Mann Island to your left.

The Museum is devoted to the history of Liverpool. Once inside, head straight for **The Great Port gallery**, which tells the story of how Liverpool grew from a small muddy tidal inlet into one of the greatest ports in the world. This is the arc of Blundell's entire life, played out in fascinating objects, maps, and models. The small market town of his childhood, the ambition of its merchants, the first dock, the Atlantic trade routes; it is all here.

As you walk through it, bear in mind that the man whose story you are tracing today was part of this transformation. He lobbied for new docks. He sat on civic committees. He sailed these trade routes from the age of twelve. He served twice as Mayor of the town.

Take time to soak up the atmosphere of the building itself too, its enormous windows look directly out across the Mersey, the river that shaped everything.

On a clear day you can see the Wirral shore that Blundell would have watched disappear behind him as a boy, leaving for Barbados for the first time.



Stop 3 Merseyside Maritime Museum and the International Slavery Museum – currently closed until 2028

Walking time 5 minutes

Address: Albert Dock, Liverpool L3 4AQ

Open: Currently closed until 2028

As you exit, walk south along the Albert Dock waterfront to where the Merseyside Maritime Museum and International Slavery Museum stand. The museums are currently closed for a major redevelopment and are due to reopen in 2028. When they do, they will be transformed: new galleries, a striking new entrance pavilion, and a bridge connecting the two museums across the dock. It will be worth the wait.

In the meantime, pause here on the quayside. You are standing yards from where eighteenth-century slave trading ships were repaired, fitted out and then sent out to sea.

This is where Blundell's story finds its most difficult chapters. His early fortune was built on tobacco and sugar. Later he went further, investing directly in the trafficking of enslaved people themselves. He lobbied for the expansion of the trade and was a prominent member of organisations that facilitated it. His descendants continued slaving voyages until 1808, two full generations after his death in 1756.

The same man who co-founded a school for Liverpool's poor children was complicit in a system that condemned others to unimaginable suffering. When the museum reopens in 2028, it will hold that truth unflinchingly. It will be worth coming back for.



Stop 4 The Old Dock (Tour or Viewing Window)

Walking time 6 minutes

Tour meeting point: The large anchor outside Merseyside Maritime Museum, Royal Albert Dock

Tours: Wed, Fri and alternate Thu & Sat · 10:30am, 12:00pm and 2:30pm · approx. 1 hour

Booking: Essential — book at liverpoolmuseums.org.uk

This is one of the most extraordinary historical experiences Liverpool has to offer, and one that is directly, intimately connected to Bryan Blundell's story.

Opened on 31 August 1715, the Old Dock was the world's first commercial enclosed wet dock. Before it existed, ships were moored in the River Mersey, and cargo was ferried ashore in small flat-bottomed boats. The huge tidal range of the Mersey meant loading and unloading was slow, difficult, and weather-dependent. The Old Dock changed everything: for the first time, ships could load and unload whatever the state of the tide.

The man who designed and built it was Thomas Steers, England's first major civil engineer and a man well known to Blundell. Steers took the Pool itself, the ancient tidal creek that had given Liverpool its name, and transformed it, sealing it from the river with gates and lining it with quaysides so ships could load and unload at any state of the tide. The construction took five years, cost £12,000 (double the original estimate), and nearly bankrupted the Corporation. The finished dock was 660 feet long by 330 feet wide and could accommodate 100 ships within its 3.5 acres.

The Old Dock was transformative. For the first time, Liverpool could handle Atlantic trade at scale, whatever the tide. Its success encouraged rapid growth in overseas commerce and triggered a wave of dock construction that would eventually give Liverpool one of the greatest waterfronts in the world: Canning Dock, Salthouse Dock, Albert Dock and beyond. The Pool that had once been a muddy obstacle became the engine of a maritime powerhouse.

The dock closed in 1826, was filled in, and eventually buried beneath the modern city. It was rediscovered during excavations in 2001 and is now accessible via a guided tour that takes you underground, beneath Liverpool ONE shopping centre, where you can see the original brick dock walls rising from the bed of the old Pool.

If you are unable to join a tour, the Old Dock Viewing Window on Thomas Steers Way, Liverpool ONE, L1 8LW offers a glimpse of the original dock walls through a glass panel set into the pavement; a small but remarkable window into the foundations on which Liverpool's fortune was built.



Stop 5 The Bluecoat Arts Centre

Walking time 4 minutes

Address: School Lane, Liverpool L1 3BX

Open: Tuesday–Saturday 10:00am–5:00pm · Sunday 11:00am–5:00pm · Free entry

Refreshments: Café inside — recommended lunch stop

From the Old Dock, walk through Liverpool ONE and turn left up Lord Street, then right into Church Alley which leads directly onto School Lane. As you walk up through Liverpool ONE, you are crossing what was once the upper reach of the Pool itself; the ancient creek that gave Liverpool its name, drained and built over when the Old Dock was constructed in 1715. Paradise Street, running alongside you, follows the line of what was then called Common Shore.

The Bluecoat Arts Centre is the oldest surviving building in Liverpool city centre. It was co-founded by Bryan Blundell and the Reverend Robert Styth in 1708 as a charity school, “for teaching poor children to read and write.”

By the time of Blundell's death in 1756 there were 70 boys and 30 girls at the school, many apprenticed to local trades, but especially maritime ones. The building is beautiful, the courtyard peaceful.

Sit in the courtyard with a coffee and consider the contradiction at the heart of the man; and the 18th century town around him. He paid for this school, largely with wealth built on the Atlantic trade, on sugar grown by enslaved people, and later on direct investment in slavery itself. Faith and profit, charity and complicity, sitting side by side.

Look out for the Latin Inscription above doorway with the school motto:

“Non Sibi Sed Omnibus — Not for Oneself but for All.”



Stop 6 Walker Art Gallery — Face to Face

Walking time 10 minutes

Address: William Brown Street, Liverpool L3 8EL

Open: Tuesday–Sunday, 10:00am–5:00pm · Free entry

From the Bluecoat, walk up Bold Street, turn left along Church Street, then right up Ranelagh Street to Lime Street, and left along William Brown Street. The Walker Art Gallery is the grand neo-classical building on your right.

The Walker holds a copy of Bryan Blundell's portrait; the original hangs in the Blue Coat School in Wavertree. It shows "a sober, deliberate man: the image of the prosperous merchant he had become."

But look around the other rooms. Blundell did not inhabit his world alone. Hanging nearby is a portrait of Richard Gildart, painted by Joseph Wright of Derby in 1768. Gildart was Mayor of Liverpool three times and one of the town's most prominent slave traders. Gildart's father-in-law was Sir Thomas Johnson, the driving force behind the Old Dock. These men knew each other. They sat on the same committees, worshipped in the same churches, and grew wealthy from the same trade.

The Walker also holds several 18th-century ship bowls, which were presented by merchants to their captains on the eve of a voyage. Blundell would have given bowls just like these to the masters of his own vessels to celebrate their voyages.



Stop 7 Liverpool Town Hall — Twice Mayor

Walking time 11 minutes

Address: High Street, Liverpool L2 3SW

Note: Exterior viewing; interior by guided tour on selected dates

Leave the Walker and turn left down William Brown Street past St George's Hall. It is one of the finest neo-classical buildings in Europe, though built a century after Blundell's time. Turn left at the bottom and head west along Dale Street.

Dale Street is one of Liverpool's original seven streets, laid out when King John founded the borough in 1207. It was the main road into town from London and Manchester, busy with coaches, carts, and merchant traffic in Blundell's day. It was here on Dale Street that Liverpool's first sugar refinery was established in 1668. The refinery is long gone, as is almost everything else from the 17th and 18th centuries; the street was widened and rebuilt from the 1780s onwards. But you are walking one of the oldest routes in the city.

At the bottom of Dale Street, turn right into Exchange Flags, the paved square immediately behind the Town Hall. This was the real counting house of 18th-century Liverpool. When the ground floor of the new Town Hall proved too dark and confined for comfortable business, merchants moved outside. Exchange Flags became where deals were struck, voyages arranged, and fortunes made.

Walk round to the east side of the building on High Street and look closely at the frieze running along it before anything else. It carries panels carved in high relief: African and Indian heads, an elephant, a crocodile, a camel, exotic fruits and barrels. This was not hidden or shameful to those who commissioned it. It was a declaration.

"the carved African and Indian heads and friezes: elephants, crocodiles, camels, exotic fruits. The source of Liverpool's newfound wealth, etched in stone — a message cast in masonry, to visitor, rival, and heir alike."

— *The Story of Bryan Blundell*

Note that when the west elevation was added around 1792, as the slave trade was becoming increasingly controversial, the carvers quietly dropped the African imagery. Marine horses, cornucopias, ropes and anchors replaced it. No direct reference to Africa. The stone itself tells the story of a town beginning to look away.

Nevertheless, between 1787 and 1807 every single Liverpool mayor was involved in the transatlantic slave trade, including two of Blundell's grandchildren and one great-grandchild. The present building dates from 1749–54, constructed in the final years of his life.



Stop 8 St Nicholas Church — Where It All Ended

Walking time 4 minutes

Address: Old Churchyard, Liverpool L2 8TZ

Open: Monday–Sunday, 9:00am–5:00pm

From the Town Hall, walk down Water Street and back north along the waterfront, returning to St Nicholas Church. End here, at the church where Bryan Blundell's story both began and ended.

He was baptised here on 9 January 1675. He married here. He worshipped here for decades. And on 27 January 1756, he was buried in these grounds: a mariner, merchant, mayor, school founder, and slave trader.

His memorial stone no longer marks the spot. After the church was damaged in the Liverpool Blitz, it was moved to the chapel of the Blue Coat School in Wavertree, where it remains today.

Blundell's descendants were still trading enslaved people in 1807 when his grandson was Mayor of Liverpool, the very year the Abolition Act was passed.

Now stand in the churchyard and look up at the tower and the ship weathervane once again. On the morning of Sunday 11 February 1810, fifty-four years after Blundell's death, the spire collapsed during Sunday service, plunging into the nave below. Children from the Moorfields Charity School were filing into the churchyard as it fell. The book describes what followed:

"Twenty-eight children were pulled from the ruins. Only three survived. The dead were laid gently on the grass outside the church, row upon row. Mothers arrived, naming them. Some identified two. One woman claimed three. Their shoes were still buckled. Ribbons still tied."

The bells that had guided sailors home for centuries, the same bells that had rung in celebration when the first abolition bill failed in Parliament in 1791, were silenced in an instant.

"And in that silence, it was not the bells that echoed, but everything that had been left unsaid."

— *The Story of Bryan Blundell*



A Note from the Author

My book, *The Story of Bryan Blundell – Slave Trader*, tells his life in full. I hope this walk has brought that story, and its unfinished reckoning, a little closer.

— **Ben Shaw**